Community Health Survey

Goal: Increase skills and knowledge on concepts and procedures of conducting community survey

Specific objectives:

- Understand the terms used in community health survey, reasons and types of survey
- Describe the process of carrying a survey, biased sample and response rate in relation to survey
- Outline points to note in constructing survey tool, causes of inaccuracy and report presentation
- Describe evaluation and feedback in relation to community survey

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Definitions

- **A survey** - is defined as a brief interview or discussion with individuals about a specific topic
- **Community survey** - is a way of asking group or community members what they see as the most important needs of that group or community.
- **Questionnaire** - is a research instrument consisting of a series of questions and other prompts for the purpose of gathering information from respondents.
- **Evaluation -** is a systematic determination of a subject's merit, worth and significance, using criteria governed by a set of standards.

Reasons – The following are reasons for carrying out a survey:

- Gather information about residents, their opinion, attitude and knowledge
- Measuring behaviors and population characteristics
- Solicit community reaction to policies, proposals and solutions
- Residents assess effectiveness of program, facilities and services
- Make residence aware of problems and their effects
- Provide residence access to policy making process
- Provide opportunity for communities to influence public decisions

When can you do a community survey?

- When your group is just starting out
- When there is doubt as to what the most important needs are
- When your group members disagree on this point among themselves
- When you need to convince outside funders or supporters that you are addressing the most important community problems
- When the community asks you to do it
- When you want to be sure that you will have community support for whatever you choose to do.

Types - Each survey is classified as either Anonymous of Non-anonymous

- An anonymous survey
  - ✓ Is used to get feedback from the users allowing them to give prompt feedback anonymously.
  - ✓ No user identifiable data will be recorded for the responses they will provide including

usernames, identification particulars address etc.

- A non-anonymous survey
  - ✓ Allow you as a survey administrator to know who is giving feedback and what feedback he/she is giving.
  - ✓ In this survey type username (if user is logged in), identification particulars address, country details are recorded.

Sometimes, a survey can be divided into questionnaire and the interview.

- Questionnaires- are usually paper-and-pencil instruments that the respondent completes.
- Interviews - are completed by the interviewer based on the respondent says

Process – Good surveys start with clear theory, then the translation of theory into sensible survey questions, pre-testing and revision of questions, development and pre-testing of the survey instrument, sampling, data gathering, and, finally, data analysis.

The following is the process of planning and conducting a survey:

- Decide on your goals
  - ✓ Before you can start your research, you will need to form a clear picture in your mind of the expected outcome.
  - ✓ Identify the overall reasons for conducting the survey.
  - ✓ What will you know after you have conducted the survey? Do you need feedback on a product or your service? Is the information you are looking for of a general nature or very specific? Do you have a particular audience in mind, or will you be sending out online surveys to the general public?
  - ✓ The answers to these questions will help you to decide how to target your survey.
  - ✓ Determine the deadline for reporting the data the survey will collect. This will ensure you complete the survey on time

- Design the methodology for conducting the survey
  - ✓ Decide the procedures for conducting the survey: the number of people you will survey (sample size), how you will survey them (self-administered questionnaire or interview)

- Create a list of questions
  - ✓ Identify the questions you want the data to answer.
  - ✓ There are many different types of questions that can be used on a survey, like open questions, closed questions, matrix table questions, and single- or multi-response questions.
  - ✓ One of the benefits of designing an online survey is that participants don't have to fill in questions that are not relevant to them. Based on their answers certain questions can be skipped.
  - ✓ Develop the tools and pretest them

- Invite the participants
  - ✓ Who you want to take part in your survey will help you to decide on the best contact method.
  - ✓ Identify the study respondents and enumerators
  - ✓ You can send an email or call the participants

- ✓ Train them and assign them responsibilities

- Gather your responses
  - ✓ Determine when to start the data collection
  - ✓ It is important to assign a unique code to each participant to make sure that they only take part in your survey once.
  - ✓ Distribute survey forms. As they are returned, track the number completed.

- Analyze the results
  - ✓ Analyze your date according to your objectives.
  - ✓ Make visual representations of the data by presenting the results in tables and graphs.
  - ✓ You can also print out the data in the form of a spreadsheet, which can then be used for further analysis.
  - ✓ There are several software packages available for data analysis (Epi-info, SPSS, SAS, STATA, RA)
  - ✓ Present the analyzed report in Narratives, Graphs, Charts, Tables or Pictures

- Write a report
  - ✓ The final step in conducting online surveys is to write a report explaining your findings.
  - ✓ A successful survey will provide the answers to the questions you had about your business, product or service.
  - ✓ Use proper report writing layout
  - ✓ Provide summary of your results

Biased samples

- There are errors that may lead to inaccuracy when completing survey tools
- Biased sample means a sample has some favors on a particular subject.
- The following are causes of biasness:
  - o Unrepresentative sample - Bias often occurs when the survey sample does not accurately represent the population. It is also called selection bias.
  - Under coverage - occurs when some members of the population are inadequately represented in the sample
  - Nonresponse bias - Sometimes, individuals chosen for the sample are unwilling or unable to participate in the survey.
  - Voluntary response bias - Voluntary response bias occurs when sample members are self-selected volunteers, as in voluntary samples
  - Measurement Error- A poor measurement process can also lead to bias
  - Response bias - refers to the bias that results from problems in the response process. Some examples of response bias are given below:
    - *Leading questions* - The wording of the question may be loaded in some way to unduly favor one response over another.
    - *Social desirability* - Most people like to present themselves in a favorable light, so they will be reluctant to admit to unsavory attitudes or illegal activities in a survey, particularly if survey results are not confidential. Instead, their responses may be biased toward what they believe is socially desirable.

- Biased sample can be eliminated by applying random sampling procedures.

- Random sampling is a procedure for sampling from a population in which:
    - The selection of a sample unit is based on chance
    - Every element of the population has a known, non-zero probability of being selected.

Response rate

- Response rate - refers to the number of people who answered the survey divided by the number of people in the sample. It is also known as completion rate or return rate. It is usually expressed in the form of a percentage.
- The following are ways of increasing response rate:
    - ✓ Offering an incentive to the participant, for example, you can offer a gift, the chance of winning something in a lottery, a donation to charity, or a point's accumulation system where participant can save up points that can be exchanged for gifts.
    - ✓ Promising to share the results with your participants.

Points to be considered when constructing a survey tool

- Open ended questions with probes
- Simple and brief questions
- Avoid closed questions
- Avoid leading questions
- Start with most easy questions
- Make personal questions last
- Each question to address one issue
- When writing the questions, keep the language very simple and avoid ambiguity or double negations.
- Make questions specific
- Ask questions in a logical order
- Construct response categories carefully – let it not be too long
- Provide clear and sufficient instructions or directions including reasons for the survey

Errors leading to inaccuracy when constructing a survey tool

- Unclear objectives
- Questions not matching the survey objectives
- Questions are ambiguous
- Tool doesn't provide adequate space for data entry
- Questions are not well numbered

Survey report presentation

- Every survey must have a report. This can be a brief summary (abstract) of detailed report
- Abstract- provides a one paged summary of the survey report in terms of:
    - Title, authors particulars and introduction
    - Methodology
    - Key findings
    - Recommendations
- A detailed report is voluminous and it contains the following:
    - Title page (table of content, acknowledgements, list of abbreviations, executive summary/ preface or abstract)

- Chapter1 – Background and introduction
- Chapter2 – Literature review
- Chapter3 – Methodology/data collection process
- Chapter4 – Findings/data results and interpretations
- Chapter5 – Discussions of the findings using your own thoughts and opinion
- Chapter6 – Conclusions and recommendations – this can also include detailed implementation plan
- Reference

Evaluation and feedback

- Evaluation – is an appraisal of something to determine its worth or fitness.
- It can be done before starting a project (Formative) or after completion of the project (Summative)
- The reasons for evaluation are:
  - It can assist an organization, program, project or any other intervention or initiative to assess any aim, realizable concept/proposal, or any alternative,
  - To help in decision-making;
  - To ascertain the degree of achievement or value in regard to the aim and objectives and results of any such action that has been completed.[l]
  - Is to enable reflection and assist in the identification of future change
  - Determines if specific program strategies were implemented as planned
  - Focuses on program implementation
  - Helps to draw conclusions about five main aspects of the intervention:
    - ✓ Relevance
    - ✓ Effectiveness
    - ✓ Efficiency - Finally, cost-benefit or cost-effectiveness analysis assesses the efficiency of a program. Evaluators outline the benefits and cost of the program for comparison. An efficient program has a lower cost-benefit ratio.
    - ✓ Impact
    - ✓ Sustainability
- Program evaluations can involve both **quantitative** and **qualitative** methods of social research
- Monitoring is a systematic and routine collection of information from projects and programmes for four main purposes:
  - To learn from experiences to improve practices and activities in the future;
  - To have internal and external accountability of the resources used and the results obtained;
  - To take informed decisions on the on-running actions
- Monitoring and evaluation uses **indicators** to for measurement and in drawing conclusions
- Indicators are statistics used to measure current conditions as well as forecasting or predicting trends. They measure change over time. Indicators can be:
  - Input – measures efforts put in
  - Process – measures procedures
  - Output – measures immediate results

    - Outcome – measures changes that comes as a result of the outputs
- Monitoring and evaluation is implemented through a logical framework (commonly known as log-frame)
- The monitoring and evaluation log frame include:
    - Objectives of the program
    - Activities implemented
    - Measurable indicators
    - Means of verification

M&E Log frame

Objective	**Activity**	**Indicators**	**Means of verification**
To reduce the number of deaths due to diarrheal diseases from 20 per month to 15 per month by 2015	1.Distribute Chlorine to every homes	# of homes supplied with chlorine # of homes with patients with diarrhea # of chlorines distributed per home	Household survey Household survey Distribution list
	2.Educate family members in 20 homes in the use of water treatment	# of homes covered with education on use of water treatment # of family members educated on use of water treatment # of educated family members actually treating water	Education program Education report Home visit
	3.Drill 2 boreholes in the community	# of boreholes drilled in the community # of drilled boreholes has water # of people fetching water from the borehole daily	Survey Survey Survey
	4.Construct pit latrines in 30 homesteads	# of latrines constructed # of homes with latrines	Construction report Household survey

		# of constructed latrines are in use	Household survey
	5.Provide ORS to children with diarrhea	# or ORS sachets provided # of children provided with ORS	S11 form ORS register

- In any survey, there must be feedback
- A survey feedback is a process in which community members complete questionnaires on various issues, receive feedback on the results, and then take appropriate actions to address the critical needs and concerns.
- The objectives of survey feedback are:
    - To assist the organization in diagnosing its problems and developing action plan for problem-solving.
    - To assist the group members to improve the relationships through discussion of common problems.
- The following are the processes of survey feedback:
    - Data Collection - The first step in survey feedback is data collection usually by a consultant based on a structured questionnaire.
    - Feedback of Information - After the data are analyzed, feedback is given to the persons who have participated in the fulfilling up of questionnaire. The feedback may be given either orally or in a written form. In oral system of feedback, it is provided through group discussion or problem-solving sessions conducted by the consultant.
    - Follow-up Action - Survey feedback programme is not meaningful unless some follow-up action is taken based on the data collected. One such follow-up action may be to advise the participants to develop their own action plans to overcome the problems revealed by the consultant.